ENERGY 07

Ashwagandha

Root of Withania somnifera, a nightshade-family shrub; contains steroid-like withanolides and alkaloids



CLASS	STUDIED FOR	HUMAN EVIDENCE	US STATUS
Plant extract	Stress, cortisol, male hormones	Controlled human trials (small, 8-week)	Dietary supplement · not an approved drug

STUDIED FOR

Stress — HUMAN	Cortisol — HUMAN	Testosterone, DHEA-S — HUMAN + ANIMAL
Fatigue and vigor — HUMAN	Thyroid — HUMAN + ANIMAL	

Liver injury case series. Reports from Iceland, the US and India describe jaundice 2 to 12 weeks after use; 3 people with prior liver disease died.

EVIDENCE & WHAT'S KNOWN

EVIDENCE

CONTROLLED TRIALS
LEVEL 4 OF 5

- 3 placebo-controlled trials, 57 to 64 adults
- 8 weeks to 60 days each
- Liver injury described in case series

NOT YET ESTABLISHED

- Long-term safety
- Half-life in people
- A risk-free intake (DTU)
- Thyroid effects in people

HOW IT WORKS IN THE BODY

Root extract ▶ Withanolides ▶ Hormone signals ▶ Stress, hormones

- Root contains steroid-like **withanolides** and **alkaloids**
- **In rats,** effects on sex hormones, reproduction, thyroid and immune system (DTU)
- **In people,** the mechanism is not established

QUICK PRACTICAL INFO

HALF-LIFE: Not established in people	ROUTES STUDIED: By mouth (root extract capsules) in trials
PHARMACOKINETICS: Not established	SOLD AS: Dietary supplement; not FDA reviewed before sale
MONITORED IN TRIALS: Stress scores, cortisol, DHEA-S, testosterone	SPORT (WADA): Not on the 2026 list

REGULATORY

FDA	No approved drug; sold as dietary supplement
DVFA	Denmark: illegal to sell as a food
FSA	UK review ongoing; no final advice yet
WADA	Not listed

REFERENCES

1. DTU National Food Institute, risk assessment of Withania somnifera root, May 2020
2. Am J Mens Health, ashwagandha in aging, overweight men, Mar 2019
3. Hepatol Commun, ashwagandha liver injury case series, Oct 2023

Adonis Men's Health · checked Nov 2026. Research and regulator records only. Not medical advice.

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